Question: “Environmental conservation is a futile endeavour.” To what extent is this true?

Factual hook

Rising global temperatures, mass extinctions of biodiversity, and rising sea levels are becoming increasingly detrimental — humanity’s rampant destruction of the ecosystem has come back to bite us. In light of such existential threats, countries all around the world are scrambling to increase conservation efforts. Indeed, thanks to rapid advancement in technology and appropriate government policies, environmental conservation has proved effective and possible. However, a pragmatic scrutiny of the situation paints a more pessimistic narrative. With many countries still destroying the environment in pursuit of other goals, and the negligible impact on already pressing issues due to environmental damage, it may be more realistic to contest that environmental conservation may be a somewhat pointless endeavour.

Signpost

hedges

Thesis

conditional = nuanced argument

Sceptics of my argument will argue that environmental conservation should not be considered fruitless if humanity as a whole has already made significant progress in this respect. Without a doubt, environmental conservation has a prodigious impact on our climate, ecosystem and livelihoods — governments across the globe have already recognised the importance and taken concrete measures to safeguard our environment. For example, Singapore has developed the Green Plan 2030 which aims to reduce carbon emissions by 30% in the year 2030, other countries like the United Kingdom have their own blueprints such as the UK Net Zero Strategy or Finland’s policies of demarcating zones for environmental protection. With countless policymakers around the world progressively placing stronger emphasis on environmental protection, it is difficult to contest that environmental protection remains an unworthy goal. Considering the many long-term strategies in place, it may be possible for such policies to translate to tangible benefits such as the slowing down of global warming, reversing the trend of increasing extinctions and attenuating the impact of erratic weather. In addition, the effectiveness and good government would only be bolstered by the advancements of technology. While rising levels of CO2 in the atmosphere once seemed like an irreversible trend, the discovery of Carbon-Capture technologies have cast doubts on such a pessimistic statement. The proliferation of greener technologies such as electric vehicles, and solar technology has further reduced the burden on the environment that human activity has. With the rapid advancements and heavy investments made into such technologies, it may be possible that our environmental conservation efforts would one day be highly significant. If we continue to be dedicated in our efforts and innovate in our solutions, it may be entirely possible for humanity to phase out fossil fuels for cleaner renewables one day and drastically alleviate our

stakeholder involved

Elaborat^n on how humanity has made progress

E.g. across ctys! Shows political angle across geographic space.

scientific angle

* How to justify that progress has been made?

political angle: policies from dif. ctys.

scientific angle: tech.

Who have significant roles to play? Govt Tech. Indiv?

environmental pollution, possibly achieving the desired outcomes of environmental conservation. In that light, environmental conservation has had significant progress and may achieve its desirable outcomes.

However, a more pragmatic scrutiny of the current situation would reveal a different picture — many countries are still prioritising other objectives over environmental conservation. Even if one country remains dedicated to the cause, its efforts may simply be overwhelmed by the lack of cooperation from other parties. At the end of the day, environmental conservation is a global responsibility that demands collaboration from all countries around the world and the entirety of humanity. For instance, while many countries have already pledged to reduce pollution of the environment and tighten environmental regulations, there remains a significant proportion that is unwilling to do so due to economic development. In less-developed countries like Nigeria are more focused on bolstering economic prosperity over environmental conservation — this has led to many incidents of environmental damage such as the Nigerian Oil Spills, where Shell infamously contaminated the environment with over 21 million barrels of oil by flouting weak environmental regulations. Unfortunately, less-developed countries like Nigeria choose to enact more tenuous regulations in hopes of attracting Multi-National Corporations (MNCs) to develop their economy. This then highlights the crux of the issue — even if developed countries are stringent on environmental protection, the polluting nature of MNCs enable them to easily re-locate their operation to less-developed countries with weaker laws. After all, the environment is shared by all nations and how effective our conservation efforts are will be dictated by the most lenient country. Unfortunately, a chain is only as strong as its weakest link. Furthermore, it would be naive to think that less-developed countries are the sole point of weakness. Developed countries have been notorious with their decisions to prioritise their own economic stability over environmental conservation with an infamous example being Donald Trump withdrawing the United States from the Paris Climate Agreement. In this regard, there are innumerable fractures in global efforts to promote environmental conservation and the pursuit of self-interest by each nation makes it challenging for any future in a scenario where significant and impactful environmental conservation can be done. With every Conference of the Parties, promises to phase out fossil fuels remain postponed indefinitely. In that light, the lack of meaningful international cooperation renders most conservation efforts ineffective and fruitless.

elaborat^{n} on how ctgs not prioritising conservat^{n} = futile efforts

shows relevance across diff. types of ctgs ⇒ adds depth to argument

In addition, in many cases environmental conservation may be pointless as it may not be able to achieve the desired goals. At the end of the day, environmental conservation efforts have been

↳ this point tackles the word "futile" ⇒ has a connotat^{n} of achieving a particular objective

sparked by issues of existential threat — rising sea levels may submerge low-lying islands and some countries may cease to exist. Considering the long-term nature of conservation efforts and the many years it would take to come to fruition, it may be unsurprising that the solutions desired by nations are focused not on conservation in the next 30-50 years, but the more imminent danger. For example, Marshall Islands is a famous case study of a nation at risk of being completely submerged due to rising sea levels. In response, the people unveiled the National Adaptation Plan which includes fortifying, building infrastructure and relocating buildings to higher ground. Similarly, one can draw parallels to other low-lying countries like Singapore whose coastlines are being increasingly eroded. To tackle this crisis, significant amounts of resources have been funnelled into coastal protection technologies to fend against rising sea levels. These examples illustrate a key insight — while conservation in the long run is definitely desirable, it is overly-idealistic to believe that conservation at present may resolve pressing concerns that are immediate. For many countries, such issues call for a more immediate solution such as technological advancements. In this regard, it would be unwise to place greater emphasis on long-term strategies like environment conservation for already imminent dangers. For countries with such concerns, it is unsurprising that they resort to other more effective measures throughout the country. Moreover, some goals of environmental conservation may possibly never be achieved even in the long run. One critical hope of conservation is to preserve the originally rich biodiversity that is dwindling in the face of deforestation and the destruction of habitats. Unfortunately, many of the world's ecosystems are unique and are unable to be recreated. Even if parts of the Amazon Rainforest previously destroyed are allowed to recover, or the bleaching corals in the Great Barrier Reef are revitalised through conservation efforts, it may not be the same as before. Species that have gone extinct or are on the verge of extinction may never rebound and environmental conservation alone may simply fall short in its ability to save these species. In many of these cases, scientists would try to breed them in captivity or even collect DNA samples as a last resort, hoping to bring the species back in the future. All these examples evince the fact that for many environmental issues plaguing us that we attempt to resolve, environmental conservation alone may be inadequate in addressing them. In that light, one could argue that environmental conservation may be meaningless if it is unable to achieve the goals that it is intended for.

again comparing btw. ctys

introduce new insights & perspectives

While such a conclusion may seem rather pessimistic, all hope is not lost. The pragmatic understanding of global cooperation and limitations of environment conservation may not spell doom for our conservation efforts. As our climate awareness as one human race increases and

young advocates like Greta Thunberg are galvanizing us to action, the reality of certain countries disregarding our environment may soon change. With greater breakthroughs in technology expected to amplify our conservation efforts, I am optimistic about the future of our world. Technology may be able to complement environment conservation efforts, making it both more effective and impactful. Ultimately, it is up to us to take charge and direct the change we hope to see. Until then, the harsh reality remains — environmental conservation now is rather meaningless.

this is the whole purpose of writing the essay & considering this question!